

Cage coaches split over rule changes

Diablo Brackin
Memphis-St. Paul Star Tribune

There is a difference of opinion as to whether this basketball season will advance the game into the 21st century or be the sport's ruin.

The controversy can be traced to two changes approved in April by the NCAA rules committee. Those 12 people — to the surprise of many coaches — voted to reduce the shot clock from 45 to 35 seconds and eliminate the five-second dribbling violation while closely guarded.

Not since the three-point shot was introduced in 1966 have rule changes prompted such heated debate.

Many coaches are baffled about why the changes were made. At the very least, critics complained, the rules were passed with almost no warning.

"I don't understand it myself," said Princeton coach Pete Carril. "To me, the game is at its height in popularity. When you see things like that, you usually don't make changes."

In a third major change, the game clock will stop after field goals in the last minute of regulation and overtime. Teams no longer can run down the clock while holding the ball out of bounds after an opponent scores. Most coaches approve of this change.

There are widespread predictions of gloom and doom stemming from the reduced shot clock and abolishment of the five-second violation. Opponents of the changes claim the 35-second clock was adopted even though 70 percent of coaches were opposed in a poll.

The elimination of the dribbling violation is even more controversial. The most-frequent complaint is that without the penalty, teams will put the ball in the hands of their best player for a one-on-one game.

From there, fears spread. The college game will be reduced to NBA-style play, in which a team clears one side of the court and lets its top player back to the basket. Critics say strategy will give way to quicker — and uglier — shots.

Many coaches predict teams will be forced to combat the one-on-one threat by playing more zone. And more zones might actually slow the look of the game, even with the new 35-second clock.

"I think there's going to be a lot more zone defenses, because offenses are going to try for a lot more isolation with guys just trying to play one-on-one," said Michigan State coach Jud Heathcote.

"In other words, guys who are really good with the ball are going to begin dribbling with 10, 15 seconds to go. It's going to be dribbling around like you see in the

pros. I hate that kind of basketball."

Said Illinois State coach Kevin Stallings of the elimination of the 5-second rule: "It could make a travesty of the game."

According to rules committee members, the changes were linked to a desire to clean up — and speed up — the final two minutes of games. Southern Cal coach George Raveling, head of the rules committee, said studies showed that the final two minutes had taken as long as 40 minutes to complete.

Committee members felt that reducing the shot clock might alleviate the need for intentional fouls in the closing minutes. With the shot clock 10 seconds shorter, committee members decided it made sense to eliminate the dribbling violation, which was considered by many to be too arbitrary a call.

Members of the rules committee say critics are overreacting. Raveling said there have been similar fears every time a major rule change has passed, and in most cases the results have proved favorable.

When the 45-second clock was introduced in 1985, the effect was minimal. Scoring increased only four-tenths of a point per game and field-goal percentage decreased two-tenths.

Said Raveling: "I would remind interested parties that there weren't a lot of coaches happy

when they put the (45-second) clock in, and not a lot of coaches were happy when they put the three-point shot in. I would suggest that history has proven that both of those moves have enhanced the game, and I think that it might well behoove all of us to wait and see what happens."

Minnesota coach Clem Haskins, a member of the rules committee, favors a patient, half-court offense but does not see the 35-second clock as a disaster.

"You're going to find the 35-second clock will not affect the game at all — at least to the point that people are worried about," Haskins said. "If you're smart, you can still control tempo with the 35-second clock."

The changes do have supporters. Iowa coach Tom Davis favors the changes because "the more we can get the tempo of the game up, the better chance we have for con-

tinued building of interest in college basketball and the success of the program."

Davis admits that the rules are a perfect fit for his trademark full-court press defense and transition offense. He does not apologize.

"This is the way the kids want to play," Davis said. "Who are you going to make rules for, the coaches? No, it should be for the players, and maybe secondly for the

fans, and I think both of them are going to like the 35-second clock change."

Haskins said, "You can't stop progress. I try to vote for what's good for the game, and for rules that follow the trend of how the game has changed. Sooner or later, they're going to move the three-point line back, widen the lanes and go to a 30-second clock, like they have in international rules."

Sports facts

Pro basketball

Most common NBA starting lineups, 1992-93:

HOME	AWAY
00	00
Rockets, 62 times (43-19, .694)	Clippers, 59 times (31-26, .525)
Vernon Maxwell	Ron Harper
Kenny Smith	Mark Jackson
Hakeem Olajuwon	Stanley Roberts
Otis Thorpe	Danny Manning
Robert Horry	Ken Norman

SOURCE: STATS Basketball Scoreboard

40	33	25	5	14
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OLMSTED FALLS HIGH SCHOOL



Olmsted Falls boys

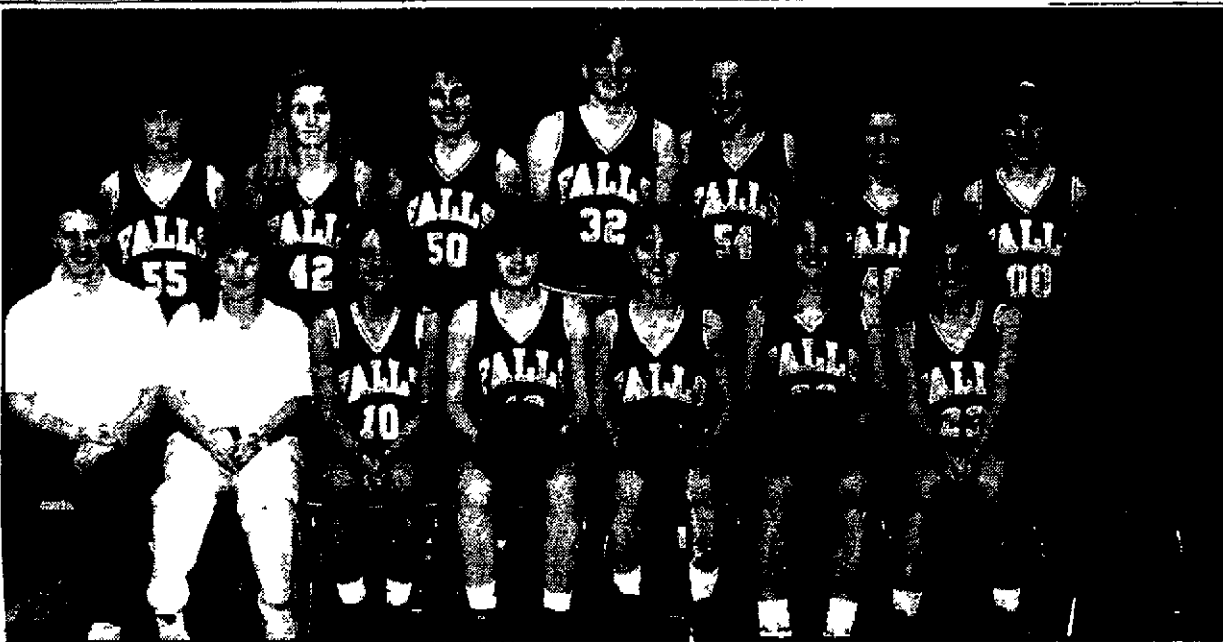
The 1993-94 Olmsted Falls boys basketball team, front row, left to right, Matt Mistak, Brian Sharp, Kevin LeMaster, Michael Nash, Dan "Moose" Mullaly, Luke Mahoney; back row, left to right, asst. coach Jeff Boddy, Jerome Moore, Kevin Monn, Tim Matus, Chris Delisio, asst. coach Nate Ludwig.

RETURNING STARTERS: Kevin LeMaster, 6-5, Sr.
OTHER RETURNING LETTERWINNERS: Mike Nash, 6-0, Sr.
RETURNING NON-LETTERWINNERS: Dan Mullaly, 6-2, Sr.; Brian Sharp, 6-1, Sr.
TOP NEWCOMERS UP FROM JUNIOR VARSITY: Tim Matus, 6-0, Soph.; Luke Mahoney, 6-2, Jr.; Chris DeLisio, 5-9, Jr.
STRENGTHS: Quickness, strong chemistry.
WEAKNESSES: Rebounding.
KEYS TO SUCCESSFUL SEASON: Rebounding and strong defense.

OLMSTED FALLS SCHEDULE

Dec. 3 — at Brookside	1992-93	1978-79
Dec. 4 — at Brooklyn	8-14	1973-74
Dec. 7 — at Midpark	1991-92	1974-75
Dec. 10 — at Avon	1990-91	1975-76
Dec. 14 — at North Ridgeville	1989-90	1976-77
Dec. 17 — at Rocky River	1988-89	1977-78
Dec. 21 — at North Olmsted	1987-88	1978-79
Dec. 29 — at Westlake	1986-87	1979-80
Jan. 8 — at Avon Lake	1985-86	1980-81
Jan. 14 — at Bay	1984-85	1981-82
Jan. 21 — at Fairview	1983-84	1982-83
Jan. 22 — at Amherst	1982-83	1983-84
Jan. 26 — at Rocky River	1981-82	1984-85
Feb. 1 — at Strongsville	1980-81	1985-86
Feb. 4 — at North Olmsted	1979-80	1986-87
Feb. 5 — at Avon Lake	1978-79	1987-88
Feb. 11 — at Westlake	1977-78	1988-89
Feb. 12 — at Bay		1989-90
Feb. 18 — at Fairview		1990-91
Feb. 25 — at Amherst		

* denotes conference game
All J.V. games start at 6, unless noted.



Olmsted Falls girls

The 1993-94 Olmsted Falls girls basketball team, front row, left to right, assist. coach Jim Meyer, assist. coach Dawn Barfield, Sarah Laut, Katie Miller, Kim MacLaren, Carrie Losneck, Carey Zoldesky, head coach Tom Gibeau; back row, left to right, Carey Theis, Kim Hardy, Megan Belt, Carissa Mahoney, Wren Lorek, Jill Benbow, Katy Mey.

Olmsted Falls

COACH: Tom Gibeau
ASSISTANTS: Dawn Barfield, Jim Meyer, Liz Houston.
1991-92 RECORDS (conference/overall): 7-7, 15-8
RETURNING STARTERS: Carrie Losneck, 5-8, Sr.; Katie Miller, 5-6, Sr.; Kim MacLaren, 5-5, Sr.
OTHER RETURNING LETTERWINNERS: Sarah Laut, 5-8, Sr.; Carey Zoldesky, 5-8, Sr.; Carissa Mahoney, 6-1, Soph.

OLMSTED FALLS SCHEDULE

Nov. 26 — John Marshall	1992-93	1978-79
Nov. 30 — North Ridgeville	8-14	1973-74
Dec. 2 — North Olmsted	1991-92	1974-75
Dec. 8 — at Amherst	1990-91	1975-76
Dec. 15 — Rocky River	1989-90	1976-77
Dec. 18 — at North Olmsted	1988-89	1977-78
Dec. 22 — at Avon Lake	1987-88	1978-79
Dec. 29 — Olmsted Falls Holiday Tournament	1986-87	1979-80
Jan. 8 — Westlake	1985-86	1980-81
Jan. 15 — at Bay	1984-85	1981-82
Jan. 22 — at Fairview	1983-84	1982-83
Jan. 26 — at Amherst	1982-83	1983-84
Jan. 29 — at Rocky River	1981-82	1984-85
Feb. 2 — at North Olmsted	1980-81	1985-86
Feb. 5 — at Avon Lake	1979-80	1986-87
Feb. 9 — at Westlake	1978-79	1987-88
Feb. 12 — at Bay	1977-78	1988-89
Feb. 15 — at Buckeye		1989-90
Feb. 27 — at Fairview		1990-91
Feb. 27 — at Clevel. Cath.		

* denotes conference game
All J.V. games start at 6, unless noted.

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